

subsidizing
the auto industry too!

CARMAGEDDON

not pay for, for the most part. And we are effectively subsidizing the wrecking of our cities for anyone else.

As the experience with the West Side Elevated Highway showed, taking away road space does not necessarily reduce people's mobility. In fact, more people were able to get into Manhattan than before. If roads were limited to the sorts of trips that cannot realistically be done any other way—transporting heavy goods or machinery for example, or disabled people who cannot realistically get up and down subway platforms, or frankly, just transporting really rich people willing to pay the actual market value of the space they are using, then there would be much less congestion.

Any sane transportation policy would think in these terms—what transport do people value, and what would they be willing to pay for. We know that access to good public transport is something that people are willing to pay money for. Ridership on the London Underground did not change much with price increases. We can also see that people are willing to pay more for public transport, because the cost of housing in places with good public transport is so expensive. Roads, by contrast, are simply, well, not that valuable—at least relative to their cost—because we already have so many. That is why private businesses almost never propose to build them anymore, even though they're easier to toll than ever.

But then the problem of the overprovision of road space goes beyond just the roads that vehicles move on. After all, 95 percent of the time, most vehicles are not moving at all.